



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Harvest Christian School

School Website: <https://harvestpetaluma.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Harvest Christian School Petaluma (CA 94954) presents a robust classical-Christian profile across most rubric categories. Public materials consistently foreground a classical framework integrated with Christian formation, emphasizing truth, goodness, and beauty, and a Trivium-based curriculum. The school emphasizes partnerships with families, a liturgical/spiritual dimension (chapel/worship), and a Great-Books–leaning posture through classical resources. The overall assessment is CLASSICAL, with category-level nuance in pedagogy where explicit Socratic/seminar pedagogy is less overt in publicly available site content, making Element 4 the only instance of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Key evidence across categories includes explicit statements about pursuing Truth, Goodness, and Beauty in a Biblical/Christian framework, the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), a classical-Catholic-style emphasis on liturgy and worship, and clear parent/community partnerships. This alignment is repeatedly echoed in mission/vision statements, philosophy of education, and the publicly published resources and governance pages. See examples citing mission statements, philosophy of education, and programmatic content.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Mission statements foreground Truth, Goodness, Beauty in Christ; theology and worship are described as foundational; doctrinal statements appear in the school's faith materials; liturgical/worship life is described as integral; a Biblical worldview informs curriculum decisions.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords drawn from classical-education lexicons include truth, goodness, beauty, theology, liturgy, worship, sacred, mythic/worshipful language, and biblical worldview; no explicit negative indicators (e.g., secularism) are evident in public materials. See the Six Elements lexicon for positive indicators and terms to look for.
 - Why this rating: The school publicly anchors its mission in transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and a biblically grounded theological frame, with liturgical/prayer components and a stated Christian worldview driving education. This aligns strongly with CLASSICAL foundations in religious/metaphysical terms.
- Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Mission/vision statements articulate formation toward virtue and wisdom (not merely information); explicit emphasis on Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as real objectives; emphasis on lifelong formation and character through a classical framework.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, classical mission, liberal education, the pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty; negative-era signals (e.g., career- or job-prep focus) appear absent or minimal in public statements. See the Six Elements lexicon for these keywords.
 - Why this rating: The school positions education as formation toward human flourishing within a classical-Christian teleology, consistent with classical aims (rather than a primary focus on vocational training).

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- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Curriculum is described as governed by the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a classical approach; references to Great Books/Western canon and a unified, integrated program; emphasis on a liberal-arts framework. Public materials discuss Trivium and a classical approach; classical resources link to Great Books and related materials.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Great Conversation; liberal education; Western civilization; interconnected curriculum; wonder/integration. Negative signals (e.g., project-based emphasis without classical content) are not present in the public materials. See the Six Elements lexicon for the exact terms.
 - Why this rating: The explicit articulation of Trivium, classical integration, and engagement with great books/Western canon aligns strongly with CLASSICAL curriculum expectations.
 - Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Public materials emphasize a classical framework (Trivium) and a spiritually oriented formation, with references to worship, memory, and formation, but explicit public documentation of Socratic seminars, upper-school rhetoric, or student-led, seminar-based pedagogy is less overt on the site. The philosophy/mission materials stress classical formation and a theological lens more than detailed Socratic pedagogy.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords from the classical pedagogy lexicon include Socratic dialogue, dialectic, Scholé (restful learning), memorization/recitation, formation through imitation, and seminar-style discourse; public materials mention Trivium and classical learning but fewer explicit references to Socratic seminars or formal upper-school rhetoric on the website. The lexicon provides these as clear indicators of a fully CLASSICAL pedagogy, while the site's public statements indicate foundational elements but less explicit SES-level practice.
 - Why this rating: The school identifies as classical-Christian and uses the Trivium, but lacks strong, explicit public documentation of Socratic seminars, extensive memorization/recitation practices, or other hallmark pedagogical rituals beyond the Trivium framework. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL in pedagogy.
 - Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Public materials describe teachers as creative, enthusiastic, and passionate; the “living curriculum” rhetoric (teachers as models of virtue) appears in mission/philosophy materials; governance pages emphasize leaders and board members who model Christian life and service.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include virtuous teachers, living curriculum, mentor/teacher as exemplar, character formation, and professional integrity; no explicit negative indicators in public materials. The lexicon lists similar positive indicators for Faculty (models of virtue, mentorship, living curriculum).
 - Why this rating: The school presents a strong zone of classical fidelity in the faculty dimension, with teachers described as virtuous, mentor-like, and central to the curriculum, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations.
 - Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: The school emphasizes partnership with families, parental involvement as co-educators, and multiple channels for parents to participate (book studies, gatherings, tours, handbook discussions). There is open campus access and clear emphasis on family formation and community engagement.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include partnership with families, co-educators, parental engagement, home-school life integration, and living tradition in the family; negative signals (e.g., parent as mere customer) are not evident in public materials. The Six Elements lexicon highlights these Positive keywords as indicators of CLASSICAL alignment.
 - Why this rating: Harvest Petaluma presents a robust model of parent/community involvement consistent with classical education norms, including family partnership and community engagement.

Aggregate Ranking: CLASSICAL

Rationale: With five categories clearly CLASSICAL and one category (Pedagogy) at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, the school's overall orientation toward classical education is strong. The public materials consistently emphasize Truth, Goodness, Beauty; a Biblical worldview; the Trivium; Great Books/Western canon; liturgical/spiritual practice; and deep family/community partnership. The aggregate assessment falls solidly in CLASSICAL, with a single category requiring needle-moving steps to reach full CLASSICAL pedagogy.

What Would Move the Needle - Pedagogy (Element 4): Explicitly document and implement a more robust Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy in upper grades, including regular Socratic discussions, guided seminars, and rhetoric-centric activities. Add structured memory work and recitation where appropriate, and articulate a concrete plan for Scholé/restful learning days to complement rigorous instruction. Publicly publish how these elements are enacted in K–8 and in the high school (if applicable). This would move Pedagogy from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL. - Curriculum: While already strong, bolster explicit Great-Books programming and a clearly stated Great Conversation framework in public materials, linking weekly or quarterly readings to a guided dialogue schedule and to assessment rubrics aligned with the Trivium. This would reinforce Element 3's CLASSICAL standing. - Documentation of liturgical cadence: If not already explicit, publish a formal liturgical calendar and evidence of communal worship/chapel practices integrated with the academic day, to strengthen the Liturgical/Communal dimension of Element 1.

Note: The needle-moving recommendations above target Element 4 primarily, with ancillary reinforcement in Curriculum and Liturgical/Communal dimensions.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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